Example 7.20

Evaluate $\begin{vmatrix} 2014 & 2017 & 0 \\ 2020 & 2023 & 1 \\ 2023 & 2026 & 0 \end{vmatrix}$.

Solution

$$\begin{vmatrix} 2014 & 2017 & 0 \\ 2020 & 2023 & 1 \\ 2023 & 2026 & 0 \end{vmatrix} = \begin{vmatrix} 2014 & 2017-2014 & 0 \\ 2020 & 2023-2020 & 1 \\ 2023 & 2026-2023 & 0 \end{vmatrix} = \begin{vmatrix} 2014 & 3 & 0 \\ 2020 & 3 & 1 \\ 2023 & 3 & 0 \end{vmatrix} = 3 \begin{vmatrix} 2014 & 1 & 0 \\ 2020 & 1 & 1 \\ 2023 & 1 & 0 \end{vmatrix}$$

$$= -3(2014 - 2023) = -3(-9) = 27.$$

Example 7.21

Find the value of x if $\begin{vmatrix} x-1 & x & x-2 \\ 0 & x-2 & x-3 \\ 0 & 0 & x-3 \end{vmatrix} = 0$.

Solution

Since all the entries below the principal diagonal are zero, the value of the determinant is $(x - 1)(x - 2)(x - 3) = 0$ which gives $x = 1, 2, 3$.

Example 7.22

Prove that $\begin{vmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ x & y & z \\ x^2 & y^2 & z^2 \end{vmatrix} = (x - y)(y - z)(z - x)$.

Solution

Applying $C_2 \to C_2 - C_1, C_3 \to C_3 - C_1$, we get

$$\text{LHS} = \begin{vmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ x & y-x & z-x \\ x^2 & y^2-x^2 & z^2-x^2 \end{vmatrix} = (y-x)(z-x) \begin{vmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ x & 1 & 1 \\ x^2 & y+x & z+x \end{vmatrix}$$

$$= (y-x)(z-x)[(z+x)-(y+x)] .$$

$$= (y-x)(z-x)(z-y) .$$

$$= (x-y)(y-z)(z-x) = \text{RHS}.$$

EXERCISE 7.2

(1) Without expanding the determinant, prove that $\begin{vmatrix} s & a^2 & b^2+c^2 \\ s & b^2 & c^2+a^2 \\ s & c^2 & a^2+b^2 \end{vmatrix} = 0$.

(2) Show that $\begin{vmatrix} b+c & bc & b^2c^2 \\ c+a & ca & c^2a^2 \\ a+b & ab & a^2b^2 \end{vmatrix} = 0$.

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